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SECURITY



## HR giant Workday says hackers stole personal data in recent breach

Zack Whittaker — 6:04 AM PDT · August 18, 2025

Workday, one of the largest providers of human resources technology, has confirmed a data breach that allowed hackers to steal personal information from one of its third-party customer relationship databases.

In [a blog post published late Friday](#), the HR technology giant said the hackers stole an unspecified amount of personal information from the database, which Workday said was primarily used to store contact information, such as names, email addresses, and phone numbers.

Workday did not explicitly rule out that customer information was taken in the data breach, stating only that there was “no indication of access to customer tenants or the data within them,” which corporate customers typically use to store the bulk of their human resources files and employees’ personal data.

The company said the stolen information may be used to further social engineering scams, where hackers trick or threaten victims into giving them access to sensitive data.

Workday has more than 11,000 corporate customers, serving at least 70 million users around the world, [per the company’s website](#). Bleeping Computer [reports](#) that the hack was discovered on August 6.

Workday did not identify the breached third-party customer database platform, but follows in a recent spate of cyberattacks targeting Salesforce-hosted databases used by large companies to store customer data. In recent weeks, [Google](#), [Cisco](#), [airline giant Qantas](#), and [retailer Pandora](#) have all had reams of data stolen from their Salesforce databases.

Google attributed the breaches to ShinyHunters, a group of hackers known for using voice phishing to steal corporate data by tricking company employees into granting them access to their cloud-based databases. Google said ShinyHunters was likely in the process of preparing a data leak site to extort its victims into paying the hackers to delete the data, akin to how ransomware gangs operate.



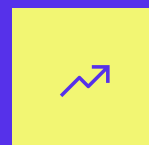
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Connor Spielmaker, a spokesperson for Workday, did not comment beyond Workday’s blog post or answer TechCrunch’s questions, including whether Workday knows how many individuals had data stolen or who the stolen data relates to, such as Workday employees or Workday’s corporate customers. Workday would not say if it has the technical means, such as logs, to determine what customer data was exfiltrated.

As of the time of publication, Workday’s blog post [disclosing the breach](#) contained a hidden “noindex” tag in its source code, which instructs search engines to ignore the page, making it difficult for anyone searching the web to find the page.

It’s not clear for what reason Workday is hiding its data breach notification from search engines.

*Do you know more about the Workday data breach or attacks targeting Salesforce databases? Have you been notified about a data breach? Securely contact this reporter via encrypted message at [zackwhittaker.1337](#) on Signal.*

*Updated with a response from Workday.*

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SECURITY



## Allianz Life data breach affects 1.1 million customers

Zack Whittaker — 3:26 PM PDT · August 18, 2025

The July data breach at U.S. insurance giant Allianz Life allowed hackers to steal the personal information of 1.1 million customers, according to data breach notification site Have I Been Pwned.

Allianz Life disclosed the data breach in late July, confirming that hackers stole the personal information of [the “majority” of its 1.4 million customers](#) and its employees from a cloud-stored customer relationship database. Allianz has so far refused to confirm exactly how many people are affected by the breach.

Have I Been Pwned, a [data breach notification site](#) that alerts people when their email address has been caught up in data breaches, said [in a post on Monday](#) the Allianz Life breach includes customers’ names, gender, date of birth, email and home addresses, and phone numbers from a database hosted by cloud giant Salesforce.

Allianz Life later told the states of Texas and Massachusetts the hackers also [stole Social Security numbers](#) in the breach.

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Brett Weinberg, a spokesperson for Allianz Life, declined to comment to TechCrunch as the company's investigation is ongoing.

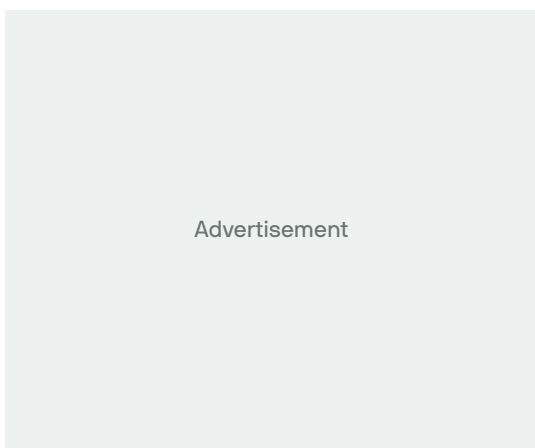
Allianz Life is one of a series of tech and corporate giants that have been targeted in recent months by a hacking crew known as ShinyHunters, a group known for their social engineering skills aimed at tricking employees into granting them access to the company's databases.

[Google](#), [Cisco](#), [airline giant Qantas](#), and [retailer Pandora](#) — and also [HR giant Workday, as reported by TechCrunch on Monday](#) — have also reported recent data thefts related to their Salesforce-hosted data.

The ShinyHunters gang is said to be preparing a data leak site in an attempt to extort victims into paying the hackers to delete the data, a tactic often employed by ransomware gangs. The group reportedly overlaps with other hacking and crime groups, [including Scattered Spider](#) and [The Com](#), a known collective of cybercriminals who use hacking, extortion, and sometimes threats of violence to break into networks.

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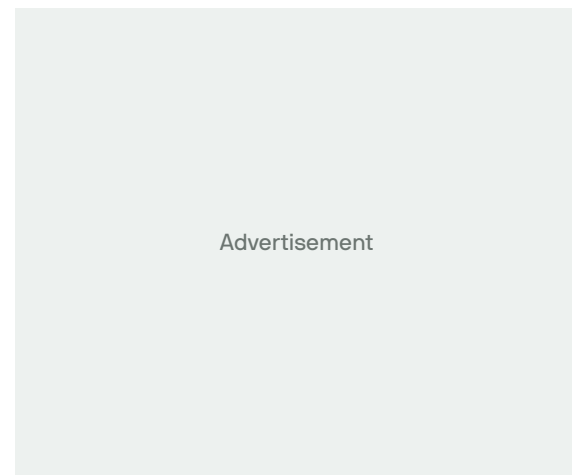
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APPS



## X's declining Android app installs are hurting subscription revenue

Sarah Perez — 1:49 PM PDT · August 18, 2025

Elon Musk's X is struggling on Android devices in terms of new installs, even while App Store downloads grow, according to new data from app intelligence provider Appfigures. In July 2025, X downloads on Google Play saw a significant decline, as new installs dropped by 44% year-over-year worldwide, even as iOS downloads grew by 15%.

This steep drop in installs is pulling down X's overall average, leading to a 26% decrease in total mobile downloads year-over-year as of July. That's still slightly better than the month prior,

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when total downloads had fallen by 35%, thanks to another sharp drop in Android downloads, which were then down by nearly half (49%) year-over-year.

### New X Downloads on Mobile by Month

Estimated Downloads • Worldwide • App Store and Google Play



IMAGE CREDITS: APPFIGURES

The firm didn’t speculate on what’s causing the decline on Android devices beyond suggesting that the X app on Android is known to be a sore spot for the company. Recently hired [X head of product Nikita Bier](#), known for growth hacking teen social apps like [Gas](#) and [TBH](#) (then [selling them](#)), has hinted that X is looking to address issues on Android, where its app is [notoriously buggy](#) and [often crashes](#).

In a post on the platform, Bier [announced](#) that X was hiring for its “Android Dream Team” to work on rebuilding the X Android app. He also recently posted that X’s iOS app [had just seen a record week in terms of installs](#), perhaps hoping to draw attention away from the large Android slump.

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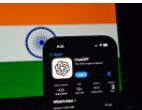
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| Month  | App Store | YoY | Google Play | YoY  | Unified    | YoY  |
|--------|-----------|-----|-------------|------|------------|------|
| Jan-24 | 2,963,000 | -   | 6,303,000   | -    | 9,266,000  | -    |
| Feb-24 | 3,623,000 | -   | 6,352,000   | -    | 9,975,000  | -    |
| Mar-24 | 3,363,000 | -   | 6,689,000   | -    | 10,052,000 | -    |
| Apr-24 | 2,971,000 | -   | 7,536,000   | -    | 10,507,000 | -    |
| May-24 | 2,993,000 | -   | 7,676,000   | -    | 10,669,000 | -    |
| Jun-24 | 3,514,000 | -   | 8,787,000   | -    | 12,301,000 | -    |
| Jul-24 | 3,429,000 | -   | 7,742,000   | -    | 11,171,000 | -    |
| Aug-24 | 3,338,000 | -   | 7,953,000   | -    | 11,291,000 | -    |
| Sep-24 | 2,679,000 | -   | 6,347,000   | -    | 9,026,000  | -    |
| Oct-24 | 2,876,000 | -   | 5,895,000   | -    | 8,771,000  | -    |
| Nov-24 | 2,629,000 | -   | 5,735,000   | -    | 8,364,000  | -    |
| Dec-24 | 2,691,000 | -   | 5,861,000   | -    | 8,552,000  | -    |
| Jan-25 | 3,312,000 | 12% | 6,019,000   | -5%  | 9,331,000  | 1%   |
| Feb-25 | 3,475,000 | -4% | 5,535,000   | -13% | 9,010,000  | -10% |
| Mar-25 | 3,359,000 | 0%  | 6,814,000   | 2%   | 10,173,000 | 1%   |
| Apr-25 | 3,029,000 | 2%  | 5,032,000   | -33% | 8,061,000  | -23% |
| May-25 | 3,370,000 | 13% | 4,766,000   | -38% | 8,136,000  | -24% |
| Jun-25 | 3,531,000 | 0%  | 4,451,000   | -49% | 7,982,000  | -35% |
| Jul-25 | 3,950,000 | 15% | 4,334,000   | -44% | 8,284,000  | -26% |

Source: Appfigures Intelligence

IMAGE CREDITS: APPFIGURES

It’s not clear where would-be X Android users are going. Rival Bluesky has seen slowing growth in recent months, and its Google Play app pulled in just 119,000 downloads in July. That’s nowhere near the millions that install X on iOS or Android every month. However, Meta’s Threads daily active users have been [catching up to X on mobile devices](#), so, possibly, some Android users could be accounted for there.

In addition to the drop in Google Play installs, X is struggling to grow its subscription revenue, Appfigures found.

In July, X earned \$16.9 million in net revenue, down from the \$18.8 million it earned in March 2025. However, that was a slight tick up from the \$16.8 million it generated in June. (Of course, X still earns the majority of its overall revenue from ads, not in-app premium subscriptions.)

While the declining demand for X on Android is partially to blame for revenue declines, X is also likely losing paying customers to Grok. The latter now has its own [stand-alone app](#) that attracts those who were buying X subscriptions primarily for the AI perks.



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Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having previously spent over three years at...

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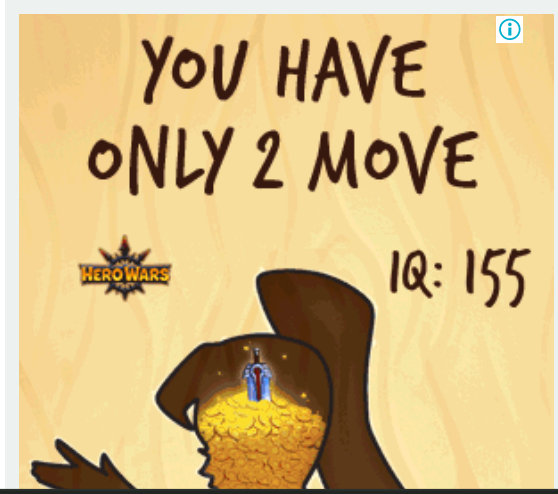
## US spy chief says UK has dropped its Apple backdoor demand

Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai

7:25 AM PDT · August 19, 2025

The U.K has dropped its demand for special access to Apple’s cloud systems, or a “backdoor,” following negotiations with the Trump administration, according to U.S. National Intelligence Director Tulsi Gabbard.

“As a result, the U.K. has agreed to drop its mandate for Apple to provide a ‘back door’ that would have enabled access to the protected encrypted data of American citizens and encroached on our civil liberties,” [Gabbard wrote in a post on X](#). She also claimed that she worked along President Donald Trump and Vice President JD Vance in the negotiations.



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[Data Protection](#) (or ADP), an opt-in security feature. ADP [turns on end-to-end encryption](#) for iCloud, meaning only the user can access their files stored on Apple’s cloud servers.

The existence of the legal demand was first reported by [The Washington Post](#) in February, which was made under the [U.K.’s Investigatory Powers Act 2016](#), also known as the Snoopers’ Charter. The request [sparked outrage and condemnation](#) from privacy and security experts worldwide, who argued that if the U.K. government obtained what it wanted, it would weaken privacy for the whole world, and also open the door for more governments to make similar demands, even in other companies’ technologies.

[Apple initially responded by removing ADP from the U.K.](#), meaning new users couldn’t turn it on. The company also said it would give guidance to existing users who “will eventually need to disable this security feature.”

In the meantime, Apple also [reportedly challenged the backdoor mandate](#) in court, a case that was initially secret but [was then ruled to be held in public](#).

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Apple and the U.K. Home Office, which initiated the demand on behalf of the British government, did not respond to requests for comment.

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Olivia Coleman, the press secretary of the U.S. Office of the Director of National Intelligence, referred to a February letter to Sen. Wyden and Rep. Biggs.

Apple previously told TechCrunch that the company has “never built a backdoor or master key” to any of its products or services and it “never will.”

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Senior Reporter, Cybersecurity | [X](#) [🦋](#) [📧](#)

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GOVERNMENT & POLICY



# How your solar rooftop became a national security issue

Connie Loizos — 1:58 PM PDT · August 15, 2025



James Showalter describes a pretty specific if not entirely implausible nightmare scenario. Someone drives up to your house, cracks your Wi-Fi password, and then starts messing with the solar inverter mounted beside your garage — that unassuming gray box that converts the direct current from your rooftop panels into the alternating current that powers your home.

“You’ve got to have a solar stalker” for this scenario to play out, says Showalter, describing the kind of person who would need to physically show up in your driveway with both the technical know-how and the motivation to hack your home energy system.

Showalter, the CEO of [EG4 Electronics](#), a company based in Sulphur Springs, Texas, doesn’t consider this sequence of events particularly likely. Still, it’s why his company last week found itself in the spotlight when U.S. cybersecurity agency CISA [published an advisory](#) detailing security vulnerabilities in EG4’s solar inverters. The flaws, CISA noted, could allow an attacker with access to the same network as an affected inverter and its serial number to intercept data, install malicious firmware, or seize control of the whole system.

For the roughly 55,000 customers who own EG4’s affected inverter model, the episode probably felt like an unsettling introduction to a device that they little understand. What they’re learning is that modern solar inverters aren’t simple power converters anymore. They now serve as the backbone of home energy installations, monitoring performance, communicating with utility companies, and, when there’s excess power, feeding it back into the grid.

Much of this has happened without people noticing. “Nobody knew what the hell a solar inverter was five years ago,” observes Justin Pascale, a principal consultant at Dragos, a cybersecurity firm that specializes in industrial systems. “Now we’re talking about it at the national and international level.”

## Security shortcomings and customers’ complaints

Some of the numbers highlight the degree to which individual homes in the U.S. are becoming miniature power plants. According to the U.S. Energy Information Administration, small-scale solar installations — primarily residential — grew [more](#)

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[than fivefold](#) between 2014 and 2022. What was once the province of climate advocates and early adopters became more mainstream owing to falling costs, government incentives, and a growing awareness of climate change.

Each solar installation adds another node to an expanding network of interconnected devices, each one contributing to energy independence but also becoming a potential entry point for someone with malicious intent.

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When pressed about his company’s security standards, Showalter acknowledges its shortcomings, but he also deflects. “This is not an EG4 problem,” he says. “This is an industry-wide problem.” Over a Zoom call and later, in this editor’s inbox, he produced a [14-page report](#) cataloguing 88 solar energy vulnerability disclosures across commercial and residential applications since 2019.

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Not all of his customers — some of whom [took to Reddit](#) to complain — are sympathetic, particularly given that CISA’s advisory revealed fundamental design flaws: communication between monitoring applications and inverters that occurred in unencrypted plain text, firmware updates that lacked integrity checks, and rudimentary authentication procedures.

“These were fundamental security lapses,” says one customer of the company, who asked to speak anonymously. “Adding insult to injury,” continues this individual, “EG4 didn’t even bother to notify me or offer suggested mitigations.”

Asked why EG4 didn’t alert customers straightaway when CISA reached out to the company, Showalter calls it a “live and learn” moment.

“Because we’re so close [to addressing CISA’s concerns] and it’s such a positive relationship with CISA, we were going to get to the ‘done’ button, and then advise people, so we’re not in the middle of the cake being baked,” says Showalter.

TechCrunch reached out to CISA earlier this week for more information; the agency has not responded. In its advisory about EG4, CISA states that “no known public exploitation specifically targeting these vulnerabilities has been reported to CISA at this time.”

## Connections to China spark security concerns

While unrelated, the timing of EG4’s public relations crisis coincides with broader anxieties about the supply chain security of renewable energy equipment.

Earlier this year, U.S. energy officials reportedly began reassessing risks posed by devices made in China after discovering unexplained communication equipment inside some inverters and batteries. [According to a Reuters investigation](#), undocumented cellular radios and other communication devices were found in equipment from multiple Chinese suppliers — components that hadn’t appeared on official hardware lists.

This reported discovery carries particular weight given China’s dominance in solar manufacturing. That same Reuters story noted that Huawei is the world’s largest supplier of inverters,

accounting for 29% of shipments globally in 2022, followed by Chinese peers Sungrow and Ginlong Solis. Some [200 GW of European solar power capacity](#) is linked to inverters made in China, which is roughly equivalent to more than 200 nuclear power plants.

The geopolitical implications haven't escaped notice. Lithuania last year [passed a law](#) blocking remote Chinese access to solar, wind, and battery installations above 100 kilowatts, effectively restricting the use of Chinese inverters. Showalter says his company is responding to customer concerns by similarly starting to move away from Chinese suppliers and toward components made by companies elsewhere, including in Germany.

But the vulnerabilities CISA described in EG4's systems raise questions that extend beyond any single company's practices or where it sources its components. The U.S. standards agency NIST [warns](#) that "if you remotely control a large enough number of home solar inverters, and do something nefarious at once, that could have catastrophic implications to the grid for a prolonged period of time."

The good news (if there is any), is that while theoretically possible, this scenario faces a lot of practical limitations.

Pascale, who works with utility-scale solar installations, notes that residential inverters serve primarily two functions: converting power from direct to alternating current, and facilitating the connection back to the grid. A mass attack would require compromising vast numbers of individual homes simultaneously. (Such attacks are not impossible but are more likely to involve targeting the manufacturers themselves, some of which have remote access to their customers' solar inverters, as [evidenced by security researchers last year](#).)

The regulatory framework that governs larger installations does not right now extend to residential systems. The North American Electric Reliability Corporation's Critical Infrastructure Protection standards [currently apply](#) only to larger facilities producing 75 megawatts or more, like solar farms.

Because residential installations fall so far below these thresholds, they operate in a regulatory gray zone where cybersecurity standards remain suggestions rather than requirements.

But the end result is that the security of thousands of small installations depends largely on the discretion of individual manufacturers that are operating in a regulatory vacuum.

On the issue of unencrypted data transmission, for example, which is one reason EG4 received that slap on the hand from CISA, Pascale notes that in utility-scale operational environments, plain text transmission is common and sometimes encouraged for network-monitoring purposes.

“When you look at encryption in an enterprise environment, it is not allowed,” he explains. “But when you look at an operational environment, most things are transmitted in plain text.”

Put another way, the real concern isn’t an immediate threat to individual homeowners. Instead it ties to the aggregate vulnerability of a rapidly expanding network. As the energy grid becomes increasingly distributed, with power flowing from millions of small sources rather than dozens of large ones, the attack surface expands exponentially. Each inverter represents a potential pressure point in a system that was never designed to accommodate this level of complexity.

Showalter has embraced CISA’s intervention as what he calls a “trust upgrade” — an opportunity to differentiate his company in a crowded market. He says that since June, EG4 has worked with the agency to address the identified vulnerabilities, reducing an initial list of 10 concerns to three remaining items that the company expects to resolve by October. The process has involved updating firmware transmission protocols, implementing additional identity verification for technical support calls, and redesigning authentication procedures.

But for those like the anonymous EG4 customer who spoke with frustration about the company’s response, the episode highlights the odd position that solar adopters find themselves in. They purchased what they understood to be climate-friendly tech, only to discover they’d become unwitting participants in a knotty cybersecurity landscape that few seem to fully comprehend.

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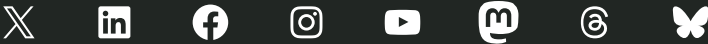
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